

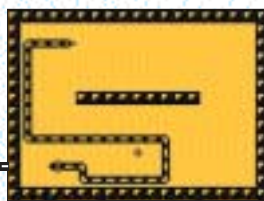
priority for most consumers. Shabbir Patanwala, 25-year accountant, for example, bought the Nokia 3330 because it was cheap and had good features. "Games do not top my priority list. I would eventually love to buy a 7650 but only because of the embedded camera." Gagan Gupta, a 25-year old game enthusiast also agrees with that point of view, "I did check for games but it was not the most important feature." He plays *Snake* on his Nokia 6510 and brags of a record score of 1600+. "If I see a score on someone's cell phone that exceeds mine, my first reaction is to break their record. It may annoy them but it entitles me to some big-time bragging rights," Gagan confesses.

Games do take on an important hue with some though. Jacob 'dumped' his Siemens cell phone only so that he could continue to play his favourite game. "I use a Nokia 3210; I bought it because I loved the game *Snake*. I had a Siemens handset, but the games in it didn't interest me at all. I owned a Motorola too, but it was even worse—it had no games at all!" His latest score is 513.

B. Mathew, the 31-year old General Manager of Fastcursor, says: "Instead of spending money on an expensive cell phone for some rudimentary game that is only neon-coloured, I choose to spend that amount on a PDA and get a better gaming console. I don't find the non-coloured pixel dominated games as interesting as those on the higher-end consoles." For hardcore gaming fanatics who are thrilled by the hunt, the kill, the blood and gore, mobile games is kid's stuff.

Here be the money

This does not mar the enthusiasm of the mobile makers, who see the gaming industry as a huge revenue-generating model. Established digital games companies are increasingly recognizing the potential of mobile gaming. Partnerships between wireless companies such as network operators or device manufacturers, and video games giants have emerged, including collaborations of Motorola with Sega, Nokia with Eidos, Orange with Rage and NTT with Nintendo. Distribution



systems that range from pre-bundling of games to downloadable content are being experimented upon; the search for maximum profit is on.

Pedro Amaro is an independent game developer based in Portugal. With game programming experience mainly in Pascal, C, C++ and Java, he's currently focused on developing games for the J2ME and J2SE platforms. He is the author of *Colourama*, the first J2ME game to be fully developed in Portugal, and to be licensed for an international release.

"Regarding distributions systems, there's one thing that I'd like to see: air time revenue sharing", says Pedro. "Currently operators only distribute the games and share the revenues of each unique sell but do not share the revenue they make with the time the player spends playing over the air. If such a feature was implemented, I suppose that over the air multiplayer gaming would takeoff. Currently, most software houses aren't interested in creating multiplayer games as the extra work doesn't pay off in financial terms."

The mobile gaming market is subject to the disruptive principles of emerging technologies, and currently plays host to a sceptical view point that mobile games are not a profitable venture.

Norbert Chang, co-founder and CEO of Enorbus, the premier provider of wireless entertainment services in China, clears the air as far as profitability is concerned. "Markets such as Japan have demonstrated the amazing potential, not only for handset sales, but for games and wireless entertainment as well. And while we admit that some in the industry have mistakenly heralded wireless games as a get-rich-quick scheme, we also insist that there is a large profit to be made." Pedro cites price as a hurdle to be cleared, "The only thing holding back this market is the cost of the latest Java-enabled colour devices, which scares away most customers. However, once that problem is solved, I am sure that those who believe that this is a non-profitable venture will change their

mind." Norbert adds that, "as a developer and content provider we are willing to work with any technology that entertains our users. We focus on exploiting the strengths of the technology, rather than dwelling on the limitations. Intelligent game design and a little creativity go a long way in developing games that maximize the opportunities of today's technology."

Games developed are as varied as the people they hope to appeal to. For instance, "I would prefer complex puzzles," says Sabira Slatewala, a 19-year old student. Or take Gagan who excitedly says "Arcade games are a must! They can add as many advanced games as they like, but classic games such as *Snake* will still be the most played ones. It's something like Windows *Solitaire* being the most popular videogame around the world." The popularity of a platform spawns a surfeit of software aimed at it, including games, a glut that attracts more users to it further raising its popularity; it is a self-contained cycle that attracts many like Gagan. "I'm really interested in getting a Nokia 7650! I've been doing some research over the Net, and have already found freeware games such as *DOOM*, *Prince of Persia*, *FIFA Soccer* and *Street Fighter*. There's a lot of free software available for it, and with the attached cam, I don't think I'll ever get bored."

It is interesting to note that the Nokia games group is a product of accident rather than a decision. George Pneumatos, Marketing Manager of Nokia Games explained that whilst developing the 6100 series of phones, some engineers recognised that the platform was sophisticated enough for games. The employees at the Product Development gave them the go-head and, "It turned out to be a lot more popular than people expected." The 6100 series of phones included three games namely *Memory*, *Logic* and *Snake*. And no sooner was it launched, than *Snake* became the most popular game. According to studies, almost 68 per cent of people with Nokia phones with *Snake* on them had played the game.

Sing when you're winning

The simplistic nature of mobile phone

Info

According to IDC survey, 15 per cent Indians play online games and 13 per cent shop online

